Dildar’s greatest challenge was to come, however. She may have enforced a fragile peace between Hindal and Humayun, but how to persuade Hamida? A few days after Dildar’s party, Humayun returned to his stepmother’s tent and sent for his beloved. Hamida refused his invitation, point-blank. She had paid her respects when Humayun first arrived, ‘Why should I come again?’

Humayun persevered. He sent a messenger to Hindal, asking for help. With grim satisfaction, perhaps, the prince told the messenger there was nothing he could do: ‘Whatever I may say, she will not go. Go yourself and tell her.’ The messenger arrived at Hamida’s tent, but had no luck. ‘To see kings once is lawful; a second time it is forbidden,’ she told him. ‘I shall not come.’[33]

When has rejection diminished love’s ardour? Hamida’s stinging refusals did not discourage Humayun. Gulbadan writes that when his messenger returned, spurned and alone, all Humayun said was, ‘If she is not a consort, we will make her a consort.’

Not only did Humayun press his suit with unflagging vigour, the courtship seems to have superseded all his other concerns – whether negotiations with Sindh or Hindal’s possible defection. Hadn’t the struggling emperor wanted Dildar to cement Hindal’s loyalty towards himself? Instead, Humayun had roped her into his romantic schemes. For forty days, Dildar coaxed Hamida, who ‘resisted and discussed and disagreed’. Eventually, Dildar produced the trump card often laid before reluctant brides. ‘After all,’ she said, ‘you will marry someone.’ And who better to marry than a king?

At this, Hamida made the reply for which she is famed: ‘Oh yes, I shall marry someone; but he shall be a man whose collar my hand can touch, and not one whose skirt it does not reach.’[34]

This can be (and often is) interpreted to mean that Hamida felt Humayun was too exalted for her, that she was expressing a humble desire for a less august match (might she have meant Hindal?). On the other hand, given Humayun’s circumstances at the time – he was living on a boat in the wilds of Sindh, eating horsemeat – it’s possible, if less flattering, that Hamida was being sarcastic. If so, Dildar ignored her, and ‘again’, writes Gulbadan, ‘gave her much advice’.

Finally, Hamida relented. Humayun was thrilled. He did the astrological